

By making yellow the dominant shade and using the remaining colours sparingly, Aldyr Garcia Schlee won the nationwide design contest that gave Brazil its iconic jersey.

Contrary to popular belief, the now-legendary Brazil vs Uruguay clash in 1950 was not technically a final. That edition did not feature knockout rounds.

Instead, the meeting between the two South American rivals in the final group-stage match became the title-deciding clash.

Brazil needed only a draw to clinch its first World Cup title. Uruguay, meanwhile, had to win to become champion.

What followed became one of football's greatest shocks. Uruguay overturned a one-goal deficit to beat Brazil, silencing the Maracanã. The emotional impact of the defeat was so profound that Brazilians came to describe it as a national tragedy — now remembered as the Maracanazo.

The sense of devastation soon entered the country's cultural imagination, rising to unimaginable levels. "Everywhere has its irremediable national catastrophe, something like a Hiroshima. Our catastrophe, our Hiroshima, was the defeat to Uruguay in 1950," wrote celebrated Brazilian playwright Nelson Rodrigues.

One of the major casualties of that tragic loss was the white kit, which was deemed not patriotic enough, lacking a strong connection to the nation's identity.

In 1953, backed by the Brazilian Football Federation, Rio newspaper *Correio da Manhã* organised a nationwide contest to design a new national-team kit, with one key condition: the jersey had to incorporate all the colours of

the Brazilian flag — green, yellow, blue and white. A total of 401 entries were submitted, featuring wildly different combinations and layouts.

The winner was 19-year-old newspaper illustrator Aldyr Garcia Schlee. His idea of making yellow the dominant shade, with minimal use of the remaining colours, proved decisive.

Schlee wasn't even a Brazil supporter. He was born in Pelotas, a small town close to the border with Uruguay, where his true allegiance lay.

Yet his design turned out to be a defining moment in Brazilian football history. The bright yellow jersey soon became an emblem of joy around the world, coming to represent Brazil's artistry and free-flowing attacking football for generations of fans.

On March 14, 1954, Brazil wore the new colours for the first time in a 1-0 win over Chile at the Maracanã. Since then, it has gone on to dominate world football, winning five World Cup titles in jerseys that still largely adhere to Schlee's original design.

As a reward for his winning entry, Schlee received a significant cash prize. But he didn't continue as a graphic designer, later becoming an award-winning journalist and writer.

Despite being feted by Brazil throughout his life, he remained a staunch Uruguay supporter. Almost poetically, he passed away on November 15, 2018 — the eve of a Brazil vs Uruguay friendly.

